

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Letter of Release

This is the most difficult chapter in this book.

We will go slowly.

You can stop reading at any time, and the chapter will still be here when you come back. The chapter is not in a hurry. You are not behind. There is no part of this you have to do today, or even this year. There is also no part of it you ever have to do, in any sense — the work in this chapter is voluntary, in every direction.

Here is what we are going to do.

We are going to talk about somebody you have been carrying.



Most people, by the time they are twelve or thirteen, are carrying somebody.

Not in a romantic sense. Not in a positive sense. Carrying, in the sense of: *there is a person who hurt you, somewhere in your past — a year ago, three years ago, in second grade, two weeks ago, sometime — and the weight of what they did has not been put down.* You think about them when you are trying to fall asleep. You think about them when something reminds you. You replay what happened. You replay what you wish you had said. You replay what they said, in the actual voice they said it in, with the exact tone, and the replay still — even now,

after all this time — makes your stomach do the thing it did at the time.

That is what carrying somebody is.

You did not sign up to carry them. You are doing it because no one ever taught you how to put them down, and because the alternative — letting them get away with what they did — felt unbearable, and so the carrying became, by default, the way you maintained some sense of justice in your own head.

The carrying does not get them.

It only gets you.

That is the central fact of this chapter, and it is so important that we are going to say it three different ways.

The person who hurt you has moved on with their life. You are reliving what they did, in your head, multiple times a day. The cost of that reliving is paid by you. It is not paid by them.

Resentment is the experience of being hurt by something that already happened. The person who hurt you has finished hurting you. You are continuing to hurt yourself, in their name, long after they have left the building.

The only person paying the price of your resentment, every day, is you.

This is not fair.

It is, in fact, one of the most unfair facts of being human — that the person who did the harm gets to walk away, and the person who absorbed the harm gets to keep paying. But it is also the structure, and pretending the structure is otherwise does not change the structure.

The Letter of Release is a tool.

The Letter of Release is one specific way, of many possible ways, to start putting somebody down.



Before we tell you how to write it, we have to say several things very clearly, because this is the chapter where misunderstandings have caused the most damage.

Release is not the same as saying what happened was okay. Release does not require you to minimize the harm. It does not require you to reframe what they did as not-that-bad. It does not require you to understand them, or to excuse them, or to give them the benefit of the doubt. It is fine to release somebody whose actions were genuinely cruel, genuinely harmful, genuinely unforgivable in the moral sense. Release does not adjudicate the moral status of what they did. Release just stops paying the cost of carrying it.

Release is not the same as reconciling with them. It is not an invitation back into your life. We covered this in Chapter Fifteen. Forgiveness and trust are different. Release lives on the forgiveness side. You can release somebody — release the weight of what they did — and still never speak to them again. That is allowed. That is, sometimes, the only sane choice.

Release is not something you owe them. They have not earned it. They may not deserve it. They may not have apologized. They may not even know they hurt you. None of that matters. Release is not for them. Release is for you. The release is happening inside your nervous system, where they have been living rent-free for too long, and you are the one signing the eviction notice.

Release is not always available. Some hurts are too fresh. Some hurts are too big. Some hurts require professional help — a therapist, a counselor, an adult who is trained to help kids carry the things kids should not have to carry alone. If you find that, when you sit down to try to write a Letter of Release, you cannot — your body will not let you, your hand will not move, you cannot find any sentences — that is a piece

of information. That is your nervous system telling you that the thing is too big for the tool yet. The tool will be available in a year, or two, or five. The thing is not the tool's failure; the thing is the size of the thing. Tell a trusted adult. Get the support that lets the tool, eventually, become usable.

That said. For the smaller carryings — the ones where the body says *I can think about this person without going into total shutdown, but I cannot put them down* — the Letter of Release is a real tool. We are going to walk you through it.



The Letter of Release has four sections.

You do not send the letter. The letter is never given to the person it is about. The letter is, in some real way, a private ritual you do for your own nervous system. The fact that it is never sent is part of what makes it work — the letter does not have to be diplomatic, does not have to be fair, does not have to make sense to anybody but you. It is for you. Nobody else will see it. You can write it in your worst handwriting. You can write it in pencil, on lined paper, in your bedroom, in your worst grammar.

Section One. What you did. Tell the person, in writing, what they did to you. In your own words. With your own anger, if you have anger. With your own sadness, if you have sadness. Without softening it. Without minimizing. Without giving them the benefit of the doubt. Just — what they did. As you experienced it.

Section Two. What it cost me. Tell the person, in writing, what it cost you to be hurt by them. The sleep you lost. The friendships that shifted. The way you saw yourself for years afterward. The version of you that did not exist after them, that might have existed without the hurt. Be specific. Be

honest. Be — and this is the hardest part — be honest with yourself about how much it cost. We minimize, often, even to ourselves. The minimizing is a defense mechanism. Drop it, for the duration of this letter.

Section Three. What I am putting down. This is the actual release part. *I am putting down the daily replay. I am putting down the imagined conversation where I finally tell you. I am putting down the surveillance of your social media to see how you are doing. I am putting down the small daily check-in I have been doing for years in my own head about you. I am putting it all down. Today. Tomorrow. Every day after.*

Section Four. What I am keeping. This is the part most curricula leave out, and it is, in some real way, the most important part. You are not erasing what happened. You are keeping certain things from the experience. *I am keeping the knowledge that I survived this. I am keeping the lessons I learned about who I am. I am keeping the friendships I built in the aftermath. I am keeping the wisdom that came from carrying you for as long as I did.* The keeping is what makes the releasing not a loss. The keeping is what turns the experience, in some real way, into a gain, even though the harm was harm.

That is the letter.

Four sections.

You can write it once. You can write it many times. Some letters get re-written across years, as the person you have been carrying changes shape in your mind. That is normal. The letter is, in some sense, a practice, not an event.



In Mr. Patel's class, in early February, the kids did the Letter of Release exercise.

Mr. Patel said, *friends. This is the heaviest exercise we are going to do all year. I am giving you the Letter of Release framework. I am also telling you that if, when you sit down, your body will not let you write — that is information. Stop. Come see me. Come see Ms. Calloway. Come see Ms. Wong. We will help you figure out what the right next step is. For some of you, that step is going to be writing the letter today. For some of you, it is going to be naming the person and the harm, in your head, this week, and writing the letter later. For some of you, it is going to be deciding, today, that this tool is not yet for you, and that is also fine. Tools are tools. Tools wait for you.*

He passed out paper.

The class wrote — or did not write — for forty minutes.

We are not going to show you any of the cohort's letters. The letters are private. Mr. Patel did not read them; we do not get to either. But we will tell you what happened in the room.

Most of the kids in the room wrote something.

Three of them — Mr. Patel could see this — wrote almost the entire forty minutes, in concentrated, hunched-over silence. Two of them — Mr. Patel could also see this — sat with the pen in their hand and could not, in the forty minutes, write a single sentence. Both of those kids, at the end of class, lingered. Both of them, in separate conversations with Mr. Patel after class, said *I think the person is too big for the letter*. Mr. Patel said, both times, *yes. That is real information. Come see me tomorrow. We will figure out the next step together.*

Both kids did. The next step, in both cases, involved Ms. Calloway and Ms. Wong and — in one case — the kid's parents. The next step, in both cases, took weeks. The next step, in both cases, was real.

That is also the Letter of Release working.

Sometimes the tool's first job is to show you that the person is bigger than the tool. That, by itself, is useful. That, by itself, lets you start asking for help.

The Letter of Release does not always produce a letter.

Sometimes it produces a conversation with a trusted adult.

Both are the work.

The work is the work.



A note to readers.

If you have, while reading this chapter, identified a person you have been carrying — somebody whose weight has been in your nervous system for too long — you are not unusual. Most twelve-year-olds, by twelve, are carrying somebody. So are most adults. The carrying is so common that most people walk around with it without realizing the carrying is not the only option.

You have options now.

You can write the letter. You can do it on a Saturday afternoon, in your bedroom, in pencil, with the door closed. You can put the letter in a drawer when you are done. You can burn the letter if you want — many people do. You can put the letter in a journal and re-read it in a year. You can do whatever you want with the letter, because the letter is yours.

You can also not write the letter today. You can sit with this chapter for a week, or a month, or a year, until the person you are thinking of feels like the right size for the tool. You can come back to this chapter at fifteen, or twenty, or forty. The tool is patient.

You can also, if the carrying is too heavy, ask for help. The 988 Lifeline is one number. Your school counselor is one option. A teacher you trust is one option. A relative who is safe

is one option. The work, in some cases, requires a witness who is trained. There is no shame in asking. The cohort in this book has many trained adults around them. You may or may not. If you do not, find one. Many adults — most adults, in fact — want to be the trained adult for a young person. They are waiting for you to ask. Ask.

The carrying is not the only option.

You have options.

You are allowed to put somebody down. You are allowed to keep something from what they did.

Both.

— J.A.R.